

60 chapters of 70 characters each. Interestingly, Xie Wangxin, vice chairman, Guangdong Literary Academy, told the official Xinhua News Agency in China that the novel was not a gimmick, and would be "a real literary work."

Some may question the state of a world where a series of SMS messages is considered a novel. While many would dismiss it as a novelty, other may think this is the beginning of a revolution—the end of the printed word.

One thing is for sure—our consumption of language, our perceptions about it, and how much leeway we give it are changing. We do seem to be becoming more liberal, more casual about how we deal with it. And that may just be a dangerous thing because it is language that distinguishes us from the apes.

Can the clarity and depth of, say, Schopenhauer's prose, be matched by the novels that will, one day, undoubtedly be written in technospeak? On the other hand, such writings will undoubtedly have their own appeal; they will communicate with their audience in ways we cannot clearly imagine now.

Vocabulary and culture are important factors when one is talking about the manner in which we communicate. Consider the word "great" or "gr8." Your friend says, "gr8" when you say, "I've passed my exam"—what does it mean? Is he happy for you? Is he congratulating you? Would he like more information? It could either mean all, none, or some of these. Responses and expressions have become standardised. This "stock-phrases phenomenon" means we are losing out on the nuances of language.

Another aspect that has become more and more evident is the fact that this phenomenon is causing us to communicate more and more mechanically. There has long been a trend of expressing less than one would like to, which technology seems to be accelerating.

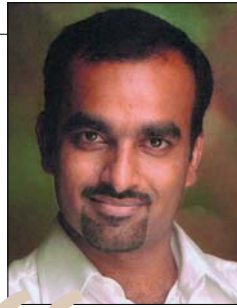
Blogs: Too Much, Too Little

A majority of blogs on the Internet have nothing of real value to say, but that is not our concern here. We are concerned with the manner in which blog posts are written: poor punctuation is rampant.

Add poor grammar in almost every posting, and you have written pieces with hardly any articulation of thought. A well-written blog, therefore, is a rare pleasure. There is information overload here: there seems to be too many people expressing too many things.

We are also changing our notion of what constitutes communication. Take picture-blogs, for instance, or MMSes. What motivates people to put up pictures on Web sites and invite others to comment on them?

It could all be put down to a hunger for communication (or attention?). Experts have voiced several times that people who use the Internet excessively to chat, e-mail, etc., are typically socially maladjusted. They feel



We do not use the English Shakespeare used. And youngsters are not using the English we used 20 years ago

Naveen Halemane,
Research Scholar,
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the need for a creative outlet that empowers them to express themselves in the manner they wish to.

On the other hand, it could also be explained in terms of the allure of technology: people who normally would not want to express much, now have new avenues of communication; they use these for the sake of using them.

Taking current trends to their logical conclusion, there will soon be a time when, at the press of a button on a device, we will know everything we want to know—and more—about a person. What's wrong with that? But then again, what's wrong with information overload?

Surviving Technology?

We live in interesting times, with everything moving at an accelerated pace. How will we communicate, say, 20 years from now? Are there certain things that will remain constant? Crystal says that certain things—like, for example, the notion of a sentence—are "hardcoded" in our brains. But of the 3,500 or so grammatical rules that Crystal estimates exist for the English language, how many of them are hardcoded? Not many, one would suppose. The language may well change dramatically.

Will there be a standardised phrase-book from which our wearable computers choose phrases to utter—Terminator style—without us actually conveying anything? Will all linguistic nuances be done away with? Will our smartphones evolve into devices that communicate sound, smell, and taste? Will luddites occupy a niche, where communication will be conducted "the old way"?

Here, Professor Crystal says that it's all about formality—there exists a "spectrum of formalities," and we use formal or informal language according to what the situation demands. However, as the average age of the Internet user goes up, we are seeing more and more of the old styles coming in. Ten years ago, Crystal says, it was unusual to see an e-mail beginning with, say, "Dear Professor Crystal"; such formalities are becoming more common.

Whatever may happen, we are clear on three points: personal communication will see information overload; we would have to choose and discard. Second: language and expression will evolve, taking on exciting new possibilities. Three, we will be increasingly to-the-point.

While still on writing, Lynne Truss, Australian author of the bestseller *Eats, Shoots and Leaves*, probably puts it best: "I've come to a new conclusion recently, that it's not actually writing that people are doing, but talking," she says. "People have actually given up writing altogether. What they're actually doing is transcribing the spoken word." ☒

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